MARKETING TRENDS · 2026

# Fashion marketing strategy trends for 2026

Nine shifts in how fashion brands reach and convert customers, from 30-minute delivery and AI search to creators, craft storytelling and community, with what Indian brands should do about each.

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**70%+**
of Myntra's new 2025 customers from non-metros

**~15%**
of e-commerce via social commerce, 2026

**35%+**
of fashion executives using generative AI

**25–35%**
apparel return rates in India

## The nine trends

Each with the evidence, sources and a practical action.

TREND 01

### Speed sells: quick-commerce fashion

Myntra's M-Now delivers in 30 minutes to 2 hours in 10+ cities; Reliance's AJIO Rush reaches 600+ cities from 1,700+ stores; start-ups like Zilo, Slikk and KNOT promise under an hour.

> **What to do:** List your best-sellers on quick-commerce channels for festive and occasion "need it tonight" moments.

Sources: Fynd

TREND 02

### Bharat is the growth market

Myntra reports that more than 70% of the new customers it onboarded in 2025 came from non-metro markets, and it is extending 30-minute delivery to cities such as Patna, Jaipur, Lucknow and Ahmedabad.

> **What to do:** Plan regional-language content, tier-II sizing and pricing, and local festival calendars.

Sources: Indian Retailer

TREND 03

## AI search changes SEO

The State of Fashion 2026 report names AI as executives' biggest opportunity and expects "generative engine optimisation" (being recommended by AI assistants) to become part of SEO. More than 35% of fashion executives already use generative AI for tasks such as copywriting and image creation.

> **What to do:** Write clear, factual product pages and guides that AI assistants can understand and quote.

Sources: FashionUnited, Shopify (citing McKinsey)

TREND 04

## Social commerce and creators

Social commerce is expected to reach about 15% of global e-commerce sales in 2026. Short video and creator content drive discovery.

> **What to do:** Work with micro-creators in your niche and make every post shoppable.

Sources: Shopify (citing Statista)

TREND 05

## Craft and provenance as the story

India Couture Week 2026 collections credited their artisans, and Prada's Kolhapuri partnership shows the value (and the risk) of heritage craft.

> **What to do:** Name the craft, region and makers in every campaign.

Sources: ETV Bharat, Prada Group

TREND 06

## Community and resale

Secondhand fashion is expected to grow two to three times faster than new through 2027, and 54% of Gen Z shoppers prefer brands that make them feel part of a community.

> **What to do:** Build loyalty clubs, styling communities and take-back or resale programmes.

Sources: FashionUnited, Shopify

TREND 07

## Cutting returns with better content

Apparel returns in India run at 25–35%, close to 40% in festive season. Virtual try-on is reported to make shoppers 50% more likely to buy.

> **What to do:** Invest in fit guides, model diversity, size recommendations and try-on tools.

Sources: Fynd, Shopify (citing DressX)

TREND 08

## Honest sustainability and AI

Greenwashing is a top buying barrier for 43% of shoppers in one survey, and AI-generated models have drawn public backlash.

> **What to do:** Make provable claims and disclose AI imagery.

Sources: Shopify, FashionNetwork

TREND 09

## Price pressure

71% of executives expect to raise prices, up from 52%, as tariffs and sourcing costs bite.

> **What to do:** Protect value perception with clear quality stories and good-better-best ranges.

Sources: FashionUnited

Statistics are quoted from the cited sources, some of which summarise third-party research; check the originals before using them in investment or budgeting decisions.